

New Zealand (Māori: [Aotearoa](#)) is an [island country](#) in the southwestern Pacific Ocean. It consists of two main landmasses—the [North Island](#) (*Te Ika-a-Māui*) and the [South Island](#) (*Te Waipounamu*)—and [over 600 smaller islands](#). It is the [sixth-largest island country](#) by area and lies east of [Australia](#) across the [Tasman Sea](#) and south of the islands of [New Caledonia](#), [Fiji](#), and [Tonga](#). The [country's varied topography](#) and sharp mountain peaks, including the [Southern Alps](#) (*Kā Tiritiri o te Moana*), owe much to [tectonic uplift](#) and volcanic eruptions. [New Zealand's capital city](#) is [Wellington](#), and its most populous city is [Auckland](#).

The islands of New Zealand were the last large habitable land to be settled by humans. Between about 1280 and 1350, [Polynesians](#) began to settle in the islands and subsequently developed a distinctive [Māori culture](#). In 1642, the Dutch explorer [Abel Tasman](#) became the first European to sight and record New Zealand. In 1769 the British explorer [Captain James Cook](#) became the first European to set foot on and map New Zealand. In 1840, representatives of the United Kingdom and [Māori](#) chiefs signed the [Treaty of Waitangi](#) which paved the way for Britain's declaration of sovereignty later that year and the establishment of the Crown [Colony of New Zealand](#) in 1841. Subsequently, [a series of conflicts](#) between the colonial government and [Māori tribes](#) resulted in the [alienation and confiscation](#) of large amounts of Māori land. New Zealand [became a dominion](#) in 1907; it [gained full statutory independence](#) in 1947, retaining the monarch as [head of state](#). Today, the majority of [New Zealand's population](#) of around 5.3 million is of [European descent](#); the indigenous Māori are the largest minority, followed by [Asians](#) and [Pasifika](#). Reflecting this, [New Zealand's culture](#) is mainly derived from Māori and early British settlers but has recently broadened from increased [immigration](#). [The official languages](#) are English, [Māori](#), and [New Zealand Sign Language](#), with the [local dialect of English](#) being dominant.

A [developed country](#), New Zealand was the first to introduce a [minimum wage](#) and give [women the right to vote](#). It [ranks very highly](#) in international measures of [quality of life](#) and [human rights](#) and has one of the lowest levels of [perceived corruption](#) in the world. It retains [visible levels of inequality](#), including [structural disparities](#) between its Māori and European populations. New Zealand underwent [major economic changes](#) during the 1980s, which transformed it from a [protectionist](#) to a [liberalised free-trade](#) economy. The [service sector](#) dominates the [country's economy](#), followed by the industrial sector, and [agriculture](#); international [tourism](#) is also a significant source of revenue. New Zealand and Australia have [a strong relationship](#) and are considered to share a strong [Trans-Tasman](#) identity, stemming from centuries of British colonisation. The country is part of [multiple international organizations and forums](#).

Nationally, legislative authority is vested in an elected, [unicameral Parliament](#), while executive political power is exercised by the [Government](#), led by the [prime minister](#), currently [Christopher Luxon](#). [Charles III](#) is the [country's king](#) and is represented by the [governor-general](#), [Cindy Kiro](#). New Zealand is organised into 11 [regional councils](#) and 67 [territorial authorities](#) for [local government](#) purposes. The [Realm of New Zealand](#) also includes [Tokelau](#) (a [dependent territory](#)); the [Cook Islands](#) and [Niue](#) (self-governing states in [free association](#) with New Zealand); and the [Ross Dependency](#), which is New Zealand's [territorial claim in Antarctica](#).

Etymology

Further information: [New Zealand place names](#)



Detail from a 1657 map showing the western coastline of Nova Zeelandia (on this map, north is at the bottom)

The first European visitor to New Zealand, Dutch explorer [Abel Tasman](#), named the islands *Staten Land*, believing they were part of the *Staten Landt* that [Jacob Le Maire](#) had sighted off the southern end of South America.^{[18][19]} The next year, in 1643, [Hendrik Brouwer](#) proved that the South American land was just a small island, and Dutch [cartographers](#) subsequently renamed Tasman's discovery *Nova Zeelandia* from [Latin](#), after the [Dutch province](#) of [Zeeland](#).^{[18][20]} This name was later [anglicised](#) to *New Zealand*.^{[21][22]}

This was written as *Nu Tirenī* in the [Māori language](#) (spelled *Nu Tirani* in Te Tiriti o Waitangi). In 1834, a document written in Māori and entitled "*He Wakaputanga o te Rangatiratanga o Nu Tirenī*" was translated into English and became the [Declaration of the Independence of New Zealand](#). It was prepared by *Te W(h)akaminenga o Nga Rangatiratanga o Nga Hapu o Nu Tirenī*, the [United Tribes of New Zealand](#), and a copy was sent to King [William IV](#) who had already acknowledged the flag of the United Tribes of New Zealand, and who recognised the declaration in a letter from [Lord Glenelg](#).^{[23][24]}

[Aotearoa](#) (pronounced [[aɔˈtɛaɾɔa](#)] in Māori and /[ˈaʊtɛəˈroʊ.ə](#)/ in English; often translated as 'land of the long white cloud')^[25] is the current Māori name for New Zealand. It is unknown whether Māori had a name for the whole country before the arrival of Europeans; *Aotearoa* originally referred to just the [North Island](#).^[26] Māori had several traditional names for the two main islands, including *Te Ika-a-Māui* ('the fish of [Māui](#)') for the North Island and *Te Waipounamu* ('the waters of [greenstone](#)') or *Te Waka o Aoraki* ('the canoe of [Aoraki](#)') for the [South Island](#).^[27] Early European maps labelled the islands North (North Island), Middle (South Island), and South ([Stewart Island / Rakiura](#)).^[28] In 1830, mapmakers began to use "North" and "South" on their maps to distinguish the two largest islands, and by 1907, this was the accepted norm.^[22] The [New Zealand Geographic Board](#) discovered in 2009 that the names of the North Island and South Island had never been formalised, and names and alternative names were formalised in 2013. This set the names as *North Island* or *Te Ika-a-Māui*, and *South Island* or *Te Waipounamu*.^[29] For each island, either its English or Māori name can be used, or both can be used together.^[29] Similarly the Māori and English names for the whole country are sometimes used together (*Aotearoa New Zealand*);^{[30][31]} however, this has no official recognition.^[32]

History

Main article: [History of New Zealand](#)

For a chronological guide, see [Timeline of New Zealand history](#).

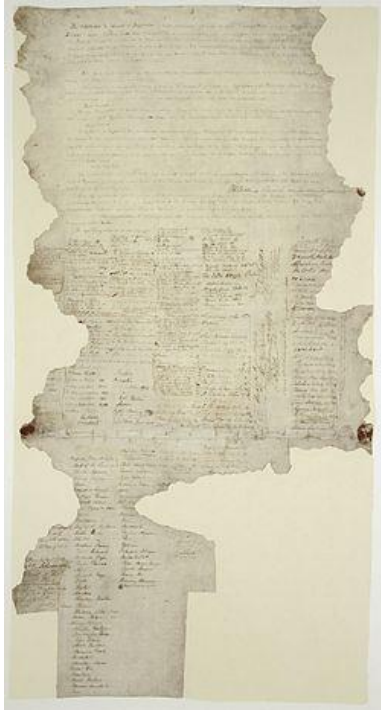


The [Māori people](#) descend from [Polynesians](#) whose ancestors emigrated from [Taiwan](#) to [Melanesia](#) between 3000 and 1000 [BCE](#) and then travelled east, reaching the [Society Islands](#) c. 1000 CE. After a pause of 200 to 300 years, a new wave of exploration led to the discovery and settlement of New Zealand. ^{[33][34][35]}

The first people to reach New Zealand were Polynesians in ocean going [waka](#), who are believed to have arrived in several waves, approximately between 1280 and 1350 CE. According to most [Māori oral traditions](#), the islands were first discovered by the semi-legendary explorer [Kupe](#) while in pursuit of a giant octopus. ^[36] These traditions held that Kupe was then followed by a great fleet of settlers, who set out from Hawaiki in eastern Polynesia in around 1350. ^[37] The existence of a single great fleet which settled New Zealand has since been superseded by the belief that the majority of settlement was a planned and deliberate event that occurred over several decades. ^{[38][39][40][41][42]} The exact date of this settlement is unclear, with recent sources favouring settlement in the 14th century. While [mitochondrial DNA](#) variability within Māori populations suggest that New Zealand was first settled between 1250 and 1300, ^{[27][43][44]} no human remains, artefacts or structures can be reliably dated to earlier than the Kaharoa eruption of [Mount Tarawera](#) in around 1314 CE. ^[45] This scenario is also consistent with a debated third line of oral evidence, ^[46] traditional genealogies ([whakapapa](#)) which point to around 1350 as a probable arrival date for several of the [migratory waka](#) (canoes) from which many Māori trace their descent. ^{[47][48]} Some Māori later migrated to the [Chatham Islands](#) where they developed their distinct [Moriōri](#) culture; ^[49] a later 1835 invasion by Māori iwi resulted in the massacre and virtual extinction of the Moriōri. ^[50]

In a hostile 1642 encounter between [Ngāti Tūmatakōkiri](#) and Dutch explorer [Abel Tasman](#)'s crew, ^{[51][52]} four of Tasman's crew members were killed, and at least one Māori was hit by [canister shot](#). ^[53] Europeans did not revisit New Zealand until 1769, when British explorer [James Cook](#) mapped almost the entire coastline. ^[52] Following Cook, New Zealand was visited by numerous European and North American [whaling](#), [sealing](#), and trading ships. They traded European food, metal tools, weapons, and other goods for timber, Māori food, artefacts, and water. ^[54] The introduction of the potato and the [musket](#) transformed Māori agriculture and warfare. Potatoes provided a reliable food surplus, which enabled longer and more sustained

military campaigns.^[55] The resulting intertribal [Musket Wars](#) encompassed over 600 battles between 1801 and 1840, killing 30,000–40,000 Māori.^[56] From the early 19th century, Christian [missionaries](#) began to settle New Zealand, eventually [converting](#) most of the Māori population.^[57] The Māori population declined to around 40% of its pre-contact level during the 19th century; introduced diseases were the major factor.^[58]



The Waitangi sheet from the [Treaty of Waitangi](#)

The [British Government](#) appointed [James Busby](#) as British Resident to New Zealand in 1832.^[59] His duties, given to him by Governor Bourke in Sydney, were to protect settlers and traders "of good standing", prevent "outrages" against Māori, and apprehend escaped convicts.^{[59][60]} In 1835, following an announcement of impending French settlement by [Charles de Thierry](#), the nebulous [United Tribes of New Zealand](#) sent a [Declaration of Independence](#) to King [William IV of the United Kingdom](#) asking for protection.^[59] Ongoing unrest, the proposed settlement of New Zealand by the [New Zealand Company](#) (which had already sent its first ship of surveyors to buy land from Māori) and the dubious legal standing of the Declaration of Independence prompted the [Colonial Office](#) to send Captain [William Hobson](#) to claim sovereignty for the [United Kingdom](#) and negotiate a treaty with the Māori.^[61] The [Treaty of Waitangi](#) was first signed in the [Bay of Islands](#) on 6 February 1840.^[62] In response to the New Zealand Company's attempts to establish an independent settlement in [Wellington](#),^{[63][64]} Hobson declared British sovereignty over all of New Zealand on 21 May 1840, even though copies of the treaty were still circulating throughout the country for Māori to sign.^[65] With the signing of the treaty and declaration of sovereignty, the number of immigrants, particularly from the United Kingdom, began to increase.^[66]

New Zealand was administered as a dependency of the [Colony of New South Wales](#) until becoming a separate [Crown colony](#), the [Colony of New Zealand](#), on 3 May 1841.^{[67][68]} Armed conflict began between the colonial government and Māori in 1843 with the [Wairau Affray](#) over land and disagreements over sovereignty. These conflicts, mainly in the North Island, saw thousands of imperial troops and the Royal Navy come to New Zealand and became known as

the [New Zealand Wars](#). Following these armed conflicts, large areas of [Māori land were confiscated by the government](#) to meet settler demands.^[69]



A meeting of European and Māori residents of [Hawke's Bay Province](#). Engraving, 1863.

The colony gained a [representative government in 1852](#), and the [first Parliament](#) met in 1854.^[70] In 1856 the colony effectively became self-governing, gaining responsibility over all domestic matters (except [native](#) policy, which was granted in the mid-1860s).^[70] Following concerns that the South Island might form a separate colony, premier [Alfred Domett](#) moved a resolution to transfer the [capital](#) from Auckland to a locality near [Cook Strait](#).^{[71][72]} Wellington was chosen for its central location, with Parliament officially sitting there for the first time in 1865.^[73]

In 1886, New Zealand annexed the volcanic [Kermadec Islands](#), about 1,000 km (620 mi) northeast of Auckland. Since 1937, the islands are uninhabited except for about six people at [Raoul Island](#) station. These islands put the northern border of New Zealand at 29 degrees South latitude.^[74] After the 1982 [UNCLOS](#), the islands contributed significantly to New Zealand's [exclusive economic zone](#).^[75]

In 1891, the [Liberal Party](#) came to power as the first organised political party.^[76] The [Liberal Government](#), led by [Richard Seddon](#) for most of its period in office,^[77] passed many important social and economic measures. In 1893, New Zealand was the first nation in the world to grant all [women the right to vote](#)^[76] and pioneered the [adoption of compulsory arbitration](#) between employers and unions in 1894.^[78] The Liberals also guaranteed a minimum wage in 1894, a world first.^[79]

In 1907, at the request of the New Zealand Parliament, King [Edward VII](#) proclaimed New Zealand a [Dominion](#) within the [British Empire](#),^[80] reflecting its self-governing status.^[81] In 1947, New Zealand [adopted](#) the [Statute of Westminster](#), confirming that the [British Parliament](#) could no longer legislate for the country without its consent. The British government's residual legislative powers were later removed by the [Constitution Act 1986](#), and final rights of appeal to British courts were abolished in 2003.^[70]

Early in the 20th century, New Zealand was involved in world affairs, fighting in the [First](#) and [Second World Wars](#)^[82] and suffering through the [Great Depression](#).^[83] The depression led to the election of the [first Labour Government](#) and the establishment of a comprehensive [welfare state](#) and a [protectionist](#) economy.^[84] New Zealand experienced increasing prosperity following the Second World War,^[85] and Māori began to leave their

traditional rural life and move to the cities in search of work.^[86] A [Māori protest movement](#) developed, which criticised [Eurocentrism](#) and worked for greater recognition of [Māori culture](#) and of the Treaty of Waitangi.^[87] In 1975, a [Waitangi Tribunal](#) was set up to investigate alleged breaches of the Treaty, and it was enabled to investigate historic grievances in 1985.^[62] The government has negotiated [settlements of these grievances](#) with many iwi,^[88] although [Māori claims to the foreshore and seabed](#) proved controversial in the 2000s.^{[89][90]}

Geography and environment

Main articles: [Geography of New Zealand](#) and [Environment of New Zealand](#)



The snow-capped [Southern Alps](#) dominate the South Island, while the North Island's [Northland Peninsula](#) stretches towards the subtropics.

New Zealand is located near the centre of the [water hemisphere](#) and is made up of two main islands and more than 700 [smaller islands](#).^[91] The two main islands (the [North Island](#), or *Te Ika-a-Māui*, and the [South Island](#), or *Te Waipounamu*) are separated by [Cook Strait](#), 22 kilometres (14 mi) wide at its narrowest point.^[92] Besides the North and South Islands, the five largest inhabited islands are [Stewart Island](#) (across the [Foveaux Strait](#)), [Chatham Island](#), [Great Barrier Island](#) (in the [Hauraki Gulf](#)),^[93] [D'Urville Island](#) (in the [Marlborough Sounds](#))^[94] and [Waiheke Island](#) (about 22 km (14 mi) from central Auckland).^[95]

New Zealand is long and narrow—over 1,600 kilometres (990 mi) along its north-north-east axis with a maximum width of 400 kilometres (250 mi)^[96]—with about 15,000 km (9,300 mi) of coastline^[97] and a total land area of 268,000 square kilometres (103,500 sq mi).^[98] Because of its far-flung outlying islands and long coastline, the country has extensive marine resources. Its [exclusive economic zone](#) is one of the largest in the world, covering more than 15 times its land area.^[99]



[Aoraki / Mount Cook](#) is the highest point in New Zealand, at 3,724 metres

The South Island is the largest landmass of New Zealand. It is divided along its length by the [Southern Alps](#).^[100] There are 18 peaks over 3,000 metres (9,800 ft), the highest of which is [Aoraki / Mount Cook](#) at 3,724 metres (12,218 ft).^[101] [Fiordland](#)'s steep mountains and deep [fiords](#) record the extensive ice age glaciation of this southwestern corner of the South Island.^[102] The North Island is less mountainous but is [marked by volcanism](#).^[103] The highly active [Taupō Volcanic Zone](#) has formed a large [volcanic plateau](#), punctuated by the North Island's highest mountain, [Mount Ruapehu](#) (2,797 metres (9,177 ft)). The plateau also hosts the country's largest lake, [Lake Taupō](#),^[91] nestled in the [caldera](#) of one of the world's most active [supervolcanoes](#).^[104] New Zealand is prone to [earthquakes](#).

The country owes its varied topography, and perhaps even its emergence above the waves, to the dynamic boundary it straddles between the [Pacific](#) and [Indo-Australian Plates](#).^[105] New Zealand is part of [Zealandia](#), a [microcontinent](#) nearly half the size of Australia that gradually submerged after breaking away from the [Gondwanan](#) supercontinent.^{[106][107]} About 25 million years ago, a shift in [plate tectonic](#) movements began to [contort and crumple](#) the region. This is now most evident in the Southern Alps, formed by [compression of the crust](#) beside the [Alpine Fault](#). Elsewhere, the plate boundary involves the [subduction](#) of one plate under the other, producing the [Puysegur Trench](#) to the south, the [Hikurangi Trough](#) east of the North Island, and the [Kermadec](#) and [Tonga Trenches](#)^[108] further north.^[105]

New Zealand, together with Australia, is part of a wider region known as [Australasia](#).^[109] It also forms the southwestern extremity of the geographic and ethnographic region called [Polynesia](#).^[110] Oceania is a wider region encompassing the [Australian continent](#), New Zealand, and various island countries in the Pacific Ocean that are not included in the [seven-continent](#) model.^[111]

Climate

Main article: [Climate of New Zealand](#)

Köppen climate types of New Zealand



Köppen-Geiger climate classification map of New Zealand



Autumn in the [Christchurch Botanic Gardens](#)

New Zealand's climate is predominantly temperate [maritime](#) (Köppen: Cfb), with mean annual temperatures ranging from 10 °C (50 °F) in the south to 16 °C (61 °F) in the north.^[112] Historical [maxima and minima](#) are 42.4 °C (108.32 °F) in [Rangiora](#), [Canterbury](#) and −25.6 °C (−14.08 °F) in [Ranfurly](#), [Otago](#).^[113] Conditions vary sharply across regions from extremely wet on the [West Coast](#) of the South Island to [semi-arid](#) in [Central Otago](#) and the [Mackenzie Basin](#) of inland Canterbury and [subtropical](#) in [Northland](#).^{[114][115]} Of the seven largest cities, [Christchurch](#) is the driest, receiving on average only 618 millimetres (24.3 in) of rain per year and Wellington the wettest, receiving almost twice that amount.^[116] Auckland, Wellington and Christchurch all receive a yearly average of more than 2,000 hours of sunshine. The southern and southwestern parts of the South Island have a cooler and cloudier climate, with around 1,400–1,600 hours; the northern and northeastern parts of the South Island are the sunniest areas of the country and receive about 2,400–2,500 hours.^[117] The general snow season is early June until early October, though [cold snaps](#) can occur outside this season.^[118] Snowfall is common in the eastern and southern parts of the South Island and mountain areas across the country.^[112]

Average daily temperatures and rainfall for selected towns and cities of New Zealand^[119]

Location	January high °C (°F)	January low °C (°F)	July high °C (°F)	July low °C (°F)	Annual rainfall mm (in)
Auckland	23 (73)	15 (59)	15 (59)	8 (46)	1,212 (47.7)
Wellington	20 (68)	14 (57)	11 (52)	6 (43)	1,207 (47.5)
Hokitika	20 (68)	12 (54)	12 (54)	3 (37)	2,901 (114.2)
Christchurch	23 (73)	12 (54)	11 (52)	2 (36)	618 (24.3)
Alexandra	25 (77)	11 (52)	8 (46)	−2 (28)	359 (14.1)

Biodiversity

Main article: [Biodiversity of New Zealand](#)



The endemic flightless [kiwi](#) is a [national icon](#).

New Zealand's [geographic isolation](#) for 80 million years^[120] and island [biogeography](#) has influenced evolution of the country's species of [animals](#), [fungi](#) and [plants](#). Physical isolation has caused biological isolation, resulting in a dynamic evolutionary ecology with examples of distinctive plants and animals as well as populations of widespread species.^{[121][122]} The flora and fauna of New Zealand were originally thought to have originated from New Zealand's fragmentation off from Gondwana, however more recent evidence postulates species resulted from dispersal.^[123] About 82% of New Zealand's indigenous [vascular plants](#) are [endemic](#), covering 1,944 species across 65 [genera](#).^{[124][125]} The number of fungi recorded from New Zealand, including lichen-forming species, is not known, nor is the proportion of those fungi which are endemic, but one estimate suggests there are about 2,300 species of lichen-forming fungi in New Zealand^[124] and 40% of these are endemic.^[126] The two main types of forest are those dominated by broadleaf trees with emergent [podocarps](#), or by [southern beech](#) in cooler climates.^[127] The remaining vegetation types consist of grasslands, the majority of which are [tussock](#).^[128]

Before the arrival of humans, an estimated 80% of the land was covered in forest, with only [high alpine](#), wet, infertile and volcanic areas without trees.^[129] Massive [deforestation](#) occurred after humans arrived, with around half the forest cover lost to fire after Polynesian settlement.^[130] Much of the remaining forest fell after European settlement, being logged or cleared to make room for pastoral farming, leaving forest occupying only 23% of the land in 1997.^[131]



The giant [Haast's eagle](#) died out when Māori hunted its main prey, the [moa](#), to extinction.

The forests were dominated by [birds](#), and the lack of mammalian predators led to some like the [kiwi](#), [kākāpō](#), [weka](#) and [takahē](#) evolving [flightlessness](#).^[132] The arrival of humans, associated changes to habitat, and the introduction of [rats](#), ferrets and other mammals led to the [extinction](#) of many bird species, including [large birds](#) like the [moa](#) and [Haast's eagle](#).^{[133][134]}

Other indigenous animals are represented by reptiles ([tuatara](#), [skinks](#) and [geckos](#)), [frogs](#),^[135] such as the protected endangered [Hamilton's Frog](#), [spiders](#),^[136] insects ([wētā](#)),^[137] and snails.^[138] Some, such as the tuatara, are so unique that they have been called [living fossils](#).^[139] Three species of bats ([one](#) since extinct) were the only sign of native land mammals in New Zealand until the 2006 discovery of bones from [a unique, mouse-sized land mammal](#) at least 16 million years old.^{[140][141]} Marine mammals, however, are abundant, with almost half the world's [cetaceans](#) (whales, dolphins, and [porpoises](#)) and large numbers of [fur seals](#) reported in New Zealand waters.^[142] Many seabirds breed in New Zealand, a third of them unique to the country.^[143] More [penguin](#) species are found in New Zealand than in any other country, with 13 of the world's 18 penguin species.^[144]

Since human arrival, almost half of the country's vertebrate species have become extinct, including at least fifty-one birds, three frogs, three lizards, one freshwater fish, and one bat. Others are endangered or have had their range severely reduced.^[133] However, New Zealand conservationists have pioneered several methods to help threatened wildlife recover, including island sanctuaries, pest control, wildlife translocation, fostering, and ecological [restoration of islands](#) and other [protected areas](#).^{[145][146][147][148]}

Government and politics

Main articles: [New Zealand Government](#) and [Politics of New Zealand](#)

See also: [International rankings of New Zealand](#)



[Charles III](#),
[King of New Zealand](#)



[Cindy Kiro](#), [Governor-General of New Zealand](#)



[Christopher Luxon](#), [Prime Minister of New Zealand](#)

New Zealand is a [constitutional monarchy](#) with a [parliamentary democracy](#),^[149] although [its constitution](#) is [not codified](#).^[150] [Charles III](#) is the [King of New Zealand](#)^[151] and thus the [head of state](#).^[152] The king is represented by the [governor-general](#), whom he appoints on the [advice](#) of the [prime minister](#).^[153] The governor-general can exercise [the Crown's prerogative powers](#), such as reviewing cases of injustice and making appointments of [ministers](#), ambassadors, and other key public officials,^[154] and in rare situations, the [reserve powers](#) (e.g. the power to dissolve Parliament or refuse the [royal assent](#) of a [bill](#) into law).^[155] The powers of the monarch and the governor-general are limited by constitutional constraints, and they cannot normally be exercised without the advice of ministers.^[155]

The [New Zealand Parliament](#) holds [legislative power](#) and consists of the king and the [House of Representatives](#).^[156] It also included an upper house, the [Legislative Council](#), until this was abolished in 1950.^[156] The [supremacy of parliament](#) over the Crown and other government institutions was established in England by the [Bill of Rights 1689](#) and has been ratified as law in New Zealand.^[156] The House of Representatives is democratically elected, and a government is formed from the party or [coalition](#) with the majority of seats. If no majority is formed, a [minority](#)

[government](#) can be formed if support from other parties during [confidence and supply](#) votes is assured.^[156] The governor-general appoints ministers under advice from the prime minister, who is by [convention](#) the [parliamentary leader](#) of the governing party or coalition.^[157] [Cabinet](#), formed by ministers and led by the prime minister, is the highest policy-making body in government and responsible for deciding significant government actions.^[158] Members of Cabinet make major decisions collectively and are therefore [collectively responsible](#) for the consequences of these decisions.^[159] The 42nd and current prime minister, since 27 November 2023, is [Christopher Luxon](#).^[160]



A statue of [Richard Seddon](#), the "[Beehive](#)" (Executive Wing), and [Parliament House](#) (right), in Parliament Grounds, [Wellington](#)

A [parliamentary general election](#) must be called no later than three years after the previous election.^[161] Almost all general elections between [1853](#) and [1993](#) were held under the [first-past-the-post](#) voting system.^[162] Since the [1996 election](#), a form of [proportional representation](#) called [mixed-member proportional](#) (MMP) has been used.^[150] Under the MMP system, each person has two votes; one is for a candidate standing in the voter's [electorate](#), and the other is for a party. Based on the 2018 census data, there are 72 electorates (which include seven [Māori electorates](#) in which only Māori can optionally vote),^[163] and the remaining 48 of the 120 seats are assigned so that representation in Parliament reflects the party vote, with the threshold that a party must win at least one electorate or 5% of the total party vote before it is eligible for a seat.^[164] Elections since the 1930s have been dominated by two [political parties](#), [National](#) and [Labour](#). More parties have been represented in Parliament since the introduction of MMP.^[165]

[New Zealand's judiciary](#), headed by the [chief justice](#),^[166] includes the [Supreme Court](#), [Court of Appeal](#), the [High Court](#), and subordinate courts.^[167] Judges and judicial officers are appointed non-politically and under strict rules regarding tenure to help maintain [judicial independence](#).^[150] This theoretically allows the judiciary to interpret the law based solely on the legislation enacted by Parliament without other influences on their decisions.^[168]

New Zealand is identified as one of the world's most stable and well-governed states.^[169] As of 2023, the country is ranked second in the strength of its democratic institutions,^[170] and third in government transparency and [lack of corruption](#).^[171] [LGBT rights](#) in the nation are also recognised as among the most tolerant in Oceania.^[172] New Zealand ranks highly for civic participation in the political process, with 82% [voter turnout](#) during recent general elections, compared to an [OECD](#) average of 69%.^[173] However, this is untrue for local council elections; a historically low 36% of eligible New Zealanders voted in the [2022 local elections](#), compared with an already low 42% turnout in [2019](#).^{[174][175][176]} A 2017 [human rights report](#) by the [United States Department of State](#) noted that the New Zealand government generally [respected the](#)

[rights](#) of individuals, but voiced concerns regarding the social status of the Māori population.^[177] In terms of [structural discrimination](#), the [New Zealand Human Rights Commission](#) has asserted that there is strong, consistent evidence that it is a real and ongoing socioeconomic issue.^[178] One example of structural inequality in New Zealand can be seen in the criminal justice system. According to the [Ministry of Justice](#), Māori are overrepresented, comprising 45% of New Zealanders convicted of crimes and 53% of those imprisoned, while only being 16.5% of the population.^{[179][180]}

Regions and external territories

Main articles: [Regions of New Zealand](#) and [Realm of New Zealand](#)



Map of regions (coloured) and territorial authorities

(outlined) in New Zealand

The early European settlers divided New Zealand into [provinces](#), which had a degree of autonomy.^[181] Because of financial pressures and the desire to consolidate railways, education, land sales, and other policies, government was centralised and the provinces were abolished in 1876.^[182] The provinces are remembered in [regional public holidays](#)^[183] and sporting rivalries.^[184]

Since 1876, various councils have administered local areas under legislation determined by the central government.^{[181][185]} In 1989, the government reorganised [local government](#) into the current two-tier structure of [regional councils](#) and [territorial authorities](#).^[186] The [249 municipalities](#)^[186] that existed in 1975 have now been consolidated into 67 territorial authorities and 11 regional councils.^[187] The regional councils' role is to regulate "the natural environment with particular emphasis on [resource management](#)",^[186] while territorial authorities are responsible for sewage, water, local roads, building consents, and other local matters.^{[188][189]} Five of the territorial councils are [unitary authorities](#) and also act as regional councils.^[189] The territorial authorities consist of 13 city councils, 53 [district](#) councils, and the [Chatham Islands Council](#). While officially the Chatham Islands Council is not a unitary authority, it undertakes many functions of a regional council.^[190]

The Realm of New Zealand, one of 15 [Commonwealth realms](#),^[191] is the entire area over which the king or queen of New Zealand is [sovereign](#) and comprises New Zealand, [Tokelau](#), the [Ross Dependency](#), the [Cook Islands](#), and [Niue](#).^[149] The Cook Islands and Niue are self-governing

states in [free association](#) with New Zealand.^{[192][193]} The New Zealand Parliament cannot pass legislation for these countries, but with their consent can act on behalf of them in foreign affairs and defence. Tokelau is classified as a [non-self-governing territory](#), but is administered by a council of three elders (one from each Tokelauan [atoll](#)).^[194] The Ross Dependency is New Zealand's [territorial claim in Antarctica](#), where it operates the [Scott Base](#) research facility.^[195] [New Zealand nationality law](#) treats all parts of the realm equally, so most people born in New Zealand, the Cook Islands, Niue, Tokelau, and the Ross Dependency are New Zealand citizens.^{[196][n.8]}

Foreign relations

Main article: [Foreign relations of New Zealand](#)



Former New Zealand prime minister [Jacinda Ardern](#) with US president [Joe Biden](#) in the [Oval Office](#), 2022

During the period of the New Zealand colony, Britain was responsible for external trade and foreign relations.^[198] The 1923 and 1926 [Imperial Conferences](#) decided that New Zealand should be allowed to negotiate its own political [treaties](#), and the first commercial treaty was ratified in 1928 with Japan. On 3 September 1939, New Zealand allied itself with Britain and [declared war](#) on Germany with Prime Minister [Michael Joseph Savage](#) proclaiming, "Where she goes, we go; where she stands, we stand".^[199]



[Māori Battalion haka](#) in Egypt, 1941

In 1951, the United Kingdom became increasingly focused on its European interests,^[200] while New Zealand joined [Australia](#) and the [United States](#) in the [ANZUS](#) security treaty.^[201] The influence of the United States on New Zealand weakened following protests over the [Vietnam War](#),^[202] the refusal of the United States to admonish France after the [sinking of the Rainbow Warrior](#),^[203] disagreements over environmental and agricultural trade issues, and [New Zealand's](#)

[nuclear-free policy](#).^{[204][205]} Despite the United States's suspension of ANZUS obligations, the treaty remained in effect between New Zealand and Australia, whose foreign policy has followed a similar historical trend.^[206] Close political contact is maintained between the two countries, with [free trade agreements](#) and [travel arrangements](#) that allow citizens to visit, live and work in both countries without restrictions.^[207] In 2013 there were about 650,000 New Zealand citizens living in Australia, which is equivalent to 15% of the population of New Zealand.^[208]

New Zealand has a strong presence among the [Pacific Island](#) countries, and enjoys strong diplomatic relations with [Samoa](#), [Fiji](#), and [Tonga](#), and among smaller nations.^[209] A large proportion of New Zealand's aid goes to these countries, and many Pacific people migrate to New Zealand for employment. The increase of this since the 1960s led to the formation of the [Pasifika New Zealander](#) pan-ethnic group, the fourth-largest ethnic grouping in the country.^{[210][211]} Permanent migration is regulated under the 1970 Samoan Quota Scheme and the 2002 Pacific Access Category, which allow up to 1,100 Samoan nationals and up to 750 other Pacific Islanders respectively to become permanent New Zealand residents each year. A seasonal workers scheme for temporary migration was introduced in 2007, and in 2009 about 8,000 Pacific Islanders were employed under it.^[212] New Zealand is involved in the [Pacific Islands Forum](#), the [Pacific Community](#), [Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation](#), and the [Association of Southeast Asian Nations](#) Regional Forum (including the [East Asia Summit](#)).^[207] New Zealand has been described as a [middle power](#) in the Asia-Pacific region,^[213] and an [emerging power](#).^{[214][215]} The country is a member of the [United Nations](#),^[216] the [Commonwealth of Nations](#)^[217] and the [Organisation for Economic Co-operation and Development](#) (OECD),^[218] and participates in the [Five Power Defence Arrangements](#).^[219]

Today, New Zealand enjoys [particularly close relations](#) with the United States and is one of its [major non-NATO allies](#),^[220] as well as with [Australia](#), with a "[Trans-Tasman](#)" identity between citizens of the latter being common.^[221] New Zealand is a member of the [Five Eyes](#) intelligence sharing agreement, known formally as the [UKUSA Agreement](#). The five members of this agreement comprise the [core Anglosphere](#): Australia, Canada, New Zealand, the United Kingdom, and the United States.^[222] Since 2012, New Zealand has had a partnership arrangement with [NATO](#) under the Partnership Interoperability Initiative.^{[223][224][225]} According to the 2024 [Global Peace Index](#), New Zealand is the 4th most peaceful country in the world.^[226]

Military

Main article: [New Zealand Defence Force](#)



[Anzac Day](#) service at the National War Memorial

New Zealand's military services—the New Zealand Defence Force—comprise the [Royal New Zealand Navy](#), the [New Zealand Army](#) and the [Royal New Zealand Air Force](#).^[227] New

Zealand's [national defence](#) needs are modest since a direct attack is unlikely.^[228] However, its military has [had a global presence](#). The country fought in both world wars, with notable campaigns in [Gallipoli](#), [Crete](#),^[229] [El Alamein](#),^[230] and [Cassino](#).^[231] The Gallipoli campaign played an important part in fostering New Zealand's [national identity](#)^{[232][233]} and strengthened the [ANZAC](#) tradition it shares with Australia.^[234]

In addition to Vietnam and the two world wars, New Zealand fought in the [Second Boer War](#),^[235] the [Korean War](#),^[236] the [Malayan Emergency](#),^[237] the [Gulf War](#), and the [Afghanistan War](#). It has contributed forces to several regional and global peacekeeping missions, such as those in [Cyprus](#), [Somalia](#), [Bosnia and Herzegovina](#), the [Sinai](#), [Angola](#), [Cambodia](#), the [Iran–Iraq border](#), [Bougainville](#), [East Timor](#), and the [Solomon Islands](#).^[238]

Economy

Main article: [Economy of New Zealand](#)

See also: [List of companies of New Zealand](#)



[Waterfront](#) along [Auckland CBD](#), a major hub of economic activity

New Zealand has an [advanced market economy](#),^[239] with the country ranked 16th in the 2022 [Human Development Index](#),^[240] and fourth in the 2022 [Index of Economic Freedom](#).^[241] It is a [high-income economy](#) with a [nominal](#) gross domestic product (GDP) per capita of United States dollar48,071 as of 2023.^[242] The currency is the New Zealand dollar, informally known as the "Kiwi dollar"; it also circulates in the Cook Islands (see [Cook Islands dollar](#)), Niue, Tokelau, and the [Pitcairn Islands](#).^[243]

Historically, extractive industries have contributed strongly to New Zealand's economy, focusing at different times on sealing, whaling, [flax](#), gold, [kauri gum](#), and native timber.^[244] The first shipment of refrigerated meat on the [Dunedin](#) in 1882 led to the establishment of meat and dairy exports to Britain, a trade which provided the basis for strong economic growth in New Zealand.^[245] High demand for agricultural products from the United Kingdom and the United States helped New Zealanders achieve higher living standards than both Australia and Western Europe in the 1950s and 1960s.^[246] In 1973, New Zealand's export market was reduced when the United Kingdom joined the [European Economic Community](#)^[247] and other compounding factors, such as the [1973 oil](#) and [1979 energy](#) crises, led to a severe [economic depression](#).^[248] Living standards in New Zealand fell behind those of Australia and Western Europe, and by 1982 New Zealand had the lowest per-capita income of all the developed nations surveyed by [the World Bank](#).^[249] In the mid-1980s New Zealand deregulated [its agricultural sector](#) by phasing out [subsidies](#) over a three-year period.^{[250][251]} Since 1984, successive governments engaged in major [macroeconomic](#) restructuring (known first as [Rogernomics](#) and then [Ruthanasia](#)), rapidly

transforming New Zealand from a [protectionist](#) and highly regulated economy to a liberalised [free-trade](#) economy.^{[252][253]} New Zealand's gold production in 2015 was 12 tonnes.^[254]



[Milford Sound / Piopiotahi](#) is one of New Zealand's most famous tourist destinations.^[255]

Unemployment peaked just above 10% in 1991 and 1992,^[256] following the [1987 share market crash](#), but eventually fell to 3.7% in 2007 (ranking third from twenty-seven comparable OECD nations).^[256] However, the [2008 financial crisis](#) had a major effect on New Zealand, with the GDP shrinking for five consecutive quarters, the longest recession in over thirty years,^{[257][258]} and unemployment rising back to 7% in late 2009.^[259] The lowest unemployment rate recorded using the current methodology was in December 2021 during the [COVID-19 pandemic](#), at 3.2%.^[260] Unemployment rates for different age groups follow similar trends but are consistently higher among youth. During the September 2021 quarter, the general unemployment rate was around 3.2%, while the unemployment rate for youth aged 15 to 24 was 9.2%.^{[256][261]} New Zealand has experienced a series of "[brain drains](#)" since the 1970s^[262] that still continue today.^[263] Nearly one-quarter of highly skilled workers live overseas, mostly in Australia and Britain, which is the largest proportion from any developed nation.^[264] In recent decades, however, a "[brain gain](#)" has brought in educated professionals from Europe and less developed countries.^{[265][266]} Today New Zealand's economy benefits from a high level of [innovation](#).^[267]

[Poverty in New Zealand](#) is characterised by growing income inequality; wealth in New Zealand [is highly concentrated](#),^[268] with the top 1% of the population owning 16% of the country's wealth, and the richest 5% owning 38%, leaving a stark contrast where half the population, including [state beneficiaries](#) and pensioners, receive less than \$24,000.^[269] Moreover, [child poverty in New Zealand](#) has been identified by the Government as a major societal issue;^{[270][271]} the country has 12.0% of children living in low-income households that have less than 50% of the median equivalised disposable household income as of June 2022.^[272] Poverty has a disproportionately high effect in ethnic-minority households, with a quarter (23.3%) of Māori children and almost a third (28.6%) of Pacific Islander children living in poverty as of 2020.^[270]

Trade

New Zealand is heavily dependent on international trade,^[273] particularly in agricultural products.^[274] Exports account for 24% of its output,^[97] making New Zealand vulnerable to international commodity prices and global [economic slowdowns](#). Food products made up 55% of the value of all the country's exports in 2014; wood was the second largest earner (7%).^[275] [New Zealand's main trading partners](#), as at June 2018, are China (NZ\$27.8b), Australia (\$26.2b), the European Union (\$22.9b), the United States (\$17.6b), and Japan (\$8.4b).^[276] On 7 April 2008, New Zealand and China signed the [New Zealand–China Free Trade Agreement](#), the first such agreement China has signed with a developed country.^[277] In July 2023, New Zealand

and the European Union entered into the [EU–New Zealand Free Trade Agreement](#), which eliminated tariffs on several goods traded between the two regions.^[278] This free trade agreement expanded on the pre-existing free trade agreement^[279] and saw a reduction in tariffs on meat and dairy^[280] in response to feedback from the affected industries.^[281]

The service sector is the largest sector in the economy, followed by manufacturing and construction and then farming and raw material extraction.^[97] [Tourism](#) plays a significant role in the economy, contributing \$12.9 billion (or 5.6%) to New Zealand's total GDP and supporting 7.5% of the total workforce in 2016.^[282] In 2017, international visitor arrivals were expected to increase at a rate of 5.4% annually up to 2022.^[282]



Wool has historically been one of New Zealand's major exports.

Wool was New Zealand's major agricultural export during the late 19th century.^[244] Even as late as the 1960s it made up over a third of all export revenues,^[244] but since then its price has steadily dropped relative to other commodities,^[283] and wool is no longer profitable for many farmers.^[284] In contrast, [dairy farming](#) increased, with the number of dairy cows doubling between 1990 and 2007,^[285] to become New Zealand's largest export earner.^[286] In the year to June 2018, dairy products accounted for 17.7% (\$14.1 billion) of total exports,^[276] and the country's largest company, [Fonterra](#), controls almost one-third of the international dairy trade.^[287] Other exports in 2017–18 were meat (8.8%), wood and wood products (6.2%), fruit (3.6%), machinery (2.2%) and wine (2.1%).^[276] [New Zealand's wine](#) industry has followed a similar trend to dairy, the number of vineyards doubling over the same period,^[288] overtaking wool exports for the first time in 2007.^{[289][290]}

Infrastructure

In 2015, [renewable energy](#) generated 40.1% of [New Zealand's gross energy](#) supply.^[291] The majority of the [country's electricity supply](#) is generated from [hydroelectric power](#), with major schemes on the [Waikato](#), [Waitaki](#) and [Clutha / Mata-Au](#) rivers, as well as at [Manapouri](#). [Geothermal power](#) is also a significant generator of electricity, with several large stations located across the [Taupō Volcanic Zone](#) in the North Island. The four main companies in the generation and retail market are [Contact Energy](#), [Genesis Energy](#), [Mercury Energy](#) and [Meridian Energy](#). State-owned [Transpower](#) operates the high-voltage transmission grids in the North and South Islands, as well as the [Inter-Island HVDC link](#) connecting the two together.^[291]

The provision of [water supply and sanitation](#) is generally of good quality. Regional authorities provide water abstraction, treatment and distribution infrastructure to most developed areas.^{[292][293]}



A [Boeing 787-9 Dreamliner](#) of [Air New Zealand](#), the flag carrier of New Zealand

[New Zealand's transport](#) network comprises 94,000 kilometres (58,410 mi) of roads, including 199 kilometres (124 mi) of motorways,^[294] and 4,128 kilometres (2,565 mi) of railway lines.^[97] Most major cities and towns are linked by bus services, although the private car is the predominant mode of transport.^[295] The [country's railways](#) were privatised in 1993 but were re-nationalised by the government in stages between 2004 and 2008. The state-owned enterprise [KiwiRail](#) now operates the railways, with the exception of commuter services in Auckland and Wellington, which are operated by [Auckland One Rail](#) and [Transdev Wellington](#) respectively.^[296] Railways run the length of the country, although most lines now carry freight rather than passengers.^[297] The road and rail networks in the two main islands are linked by [roll-on/roll-off](#) ferries between Wellington and [Picton](#), operated by [Interislander](#) (part of KiwiRail) and [Bluebridge](#). Most international visitors arrive via air.^[298] New Zealand has [four international airports](#): [Auckland](#), [Christchurch](#), [Queenstown](#) and [Wellington](#); however, only Auckland and Christchurch offer non-stop flights to countries other than Australia or Fiji.^[299]

The [New Zealand Post Office](#) had a monopoly over [telecommunications in New Zealand](#) until 1987 when [Telecom New Zealand](#) was formed, initially as a state-owned enterprise and then privatised in 1990.^[300] [Chorus](#), which was split from Telecom (now Spark) in 2011,^[301] still owns the majority of the telecommunications infrastructure, but competition from other providers has increased.^[300] A large-scale rollout of gigabit-capable [fibre to the premises](#), branded as [Ultra-Fast Broadband](#), began in 2009 with a target of being available to 87% of the population by 2022.^[302] As of 2017, the United Nations [International Telecommunication Union](#) ranks New Zealand 13th in the development of information and communications infrastructure.^[303]

Science and technology

Early indigenous contribution to science in New Zealand was by Māori [tohunga](#) accumulating knowledge of agricultural practice and the effects of herbal remedies in the treatment of illness and disease.^[304] [Cook's](#) voyages in the 1700s and [Darwin's](#) in 1835 had important scientific botanical and zoological objectives.^[305] The establishment of universities in the 19th century fostered scientific discoveries by notable New Zealanders including [Ernest Rutherford](#) for splitting the atom, [William Pickering](#) for rocket science, [Maurice Wilkins](#) for helping discover DNA, [Beatrice Tinsley](#) for galaxy formation, [Archibald McIndoe](#) for plastic surgery, and [Alan MacDiarmid](#) for conducting polymers.^[306]

[Crown Research Institutes](#) (CRIs) were formed in 1992 from existing government-owned research organisations. Their role is to research and develop new science, knowledge, products and services across the economic, environmental, social and cultural spectrum for the benefit of New Zealand.^[307] The total gross expenditure on [research and development](#) (R&D) as a proportion of GDP rose to 1.37% in 2018, up from 1.23% in 2015. New Zealand ranks 21st in the

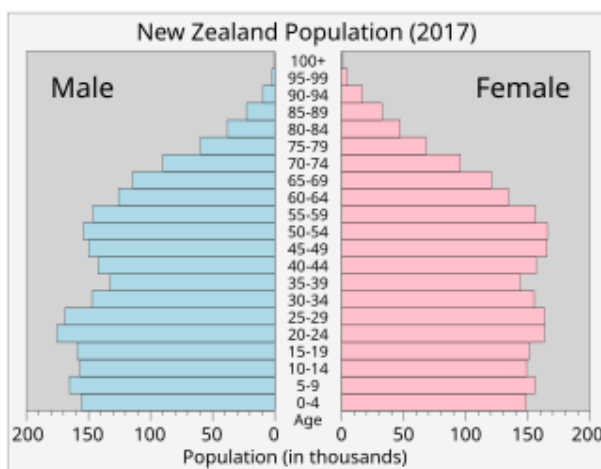
OECD for its gross R&D spending as a percentage of GDP.^[308] New Zealand was ranked 25th in the [Global Innovation Index](#) in 2024.^[309]

The [New Zealand Space Agency](#) was created by the government in 2016 for space policy, regulation and sector development. [Rocket Lab](#) was the first commercial rocket launcher in the country.^[310]

The majority of private and commercial research organisations in New Zealand are focused on the agricultural and fisheries sectors. Examples include the [Cawthron Institute](#), the [Livestock Improvement Corporation](#), the [Fonterra Research and Development Centre](#), the [Bragato Research Institute](#), the [Kiwifruit Breeding Centre](#), and [B+LNZ Genetics](#).

Demographics

Main articles: [Demographics of New Zealand](#) and [List of cities in New Zealand](#)



[Population pyramid](#) (2017)

The [2023 New Zealand census](#) enumerated a resident population of 4,993,923, an increase of 6.3% over the [2018 census](#) figure.^[4] As of July 2025, the total population has risen to an estimated 5,231,143.^[311] New Zealand's population increased at a rate of 1.9% per year in the seven years ended June 2020. In September 2020 [Statistics New Zealand](#) reported that the population had climbed above 5 million people in September 2019, according to population estimates based on the 2018 census.^{[312][n 9]}

New Zealand's population today is concentrated to the north of the country, with around 76.5% of the population living in the North Island and 23.5% in the South Island as of June 2024.^[314] During the 20th century, New Zealand's population [drifted north](#). In 1921, the country's [median centre of population](#) was located in the Tasman Sea west of [Levin](#) in [Manawātū-Whanganui](#); by 2017, it had moved 280 km (170 mi) north to near [Kawhia](#) in Waikato.^[315]

New Zealand is a predominantly urban country, with 84.7% of the population living in [urban areas](#), and 51.2% of the population living in the seven cities with populations exceeding 100,000.^[314] [Auckland](#), with over 1.4 million residents, is by far the largest city.^[314] New Zealand cities generally rank highly on international livability measures. For instance, in 2016, Auckland was ranked the world's third [most liveable city](#) and Wellington the twelfth by the Mercer Quality of Living Survey.^[316]

The [median age](#) of the New Zealand population at the 2018 census was 37.4 years,^[317] with life expectancy in 2017–2019 being 80.0 years for males and 83.5 years for females.^[318] While New Zealand is experiencing [sub-replacement fertility](#), with a total fertility rate of 1.6 in 2020, the fertility rate is above the OECD average.^{[319][320]} By 2050, the median age is projected to rise to 43 years and the percentage of people 60 years of age and older to rise from 18% to 29%.^[321] In 2016 the leading cause of death was cancer at 30.3%, followed by [ischaemic heart disease](#) (14.9%) and [cerebrovascular disease](#) (7.4%).^[322] As of 2016, total expenditure on [health care](#) (including private sector spending) is 9.2% of GDP.^[323]

- [v](#)
- [t](#)
- [e](#)

Largest cities or towns in New Zealand

[Statistics New Zealand](#) June 2024 estimate (SSGA18 boundaries)^[314]

Rank	Name	Region	Pop.	Rank	Name	Reg
1	Auckland	Auckland	1,530,500	11	Porirua	We
2	Christchurch	Canterbury	400,600	12	New Plymouth	Tara
3	Wellington	Wellington	208,800	13	Rotorua	Bay
4	Hamilton	Waikato	189,700	14	Whangārei	Nor
5	Tauranga	Bay of Plenty	161,300	15	Nelson	Nel
6	Lower Hutt	Wellington	112,300	16	Hastings	Hav
7	Dunedin	Otago	103,200	17	Invercargill	Sou
8	Palmerston North	Manawatū-Whanganui	81,800	18	Upper Hutt	We
9	Napier	Hawke's Bay	66,800	19	Whanganui	Ma
10	Hibiscus Coast	Auckland	66,800	20	Gisborne	Gis

Ethnicity and immigration

Main articles: [New Zealanders](#) and [Immigration to New Zealand](#)



Pedestrians on [Queen Street](#) in Auckland, an ethnically diverse city

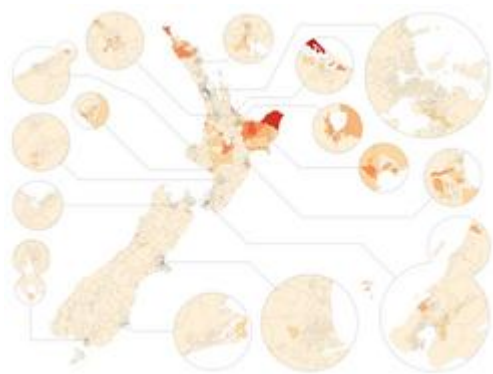
In the [2023 census](#), a total of 67.8% of New Zealand residents identified ethnically as European, with 54.1% identifying as European alone,^[324] and 19.6% as [Māori](#), with 7.3% identifying as Māori alone. Other major ethnic groups include [Asian](#) (17.3% total, 15.7% alone) and [Pacific peoples](#) (8.9%, 5.5% alone).^[325] New Zealand has a large multiethnic population, with the largest mixed groups being European and Māori (8.2%), Māori and Pacific peoples (0.9%), and European and Asian (0.9%).^[326] The population has become more multicultural and diverse in recent decades: in 1961, the census reported that the population of New Zealand was 92% European and 7% Māori, with Asian and Pacific minorities sharing the remaining 1%.^[326] However, New Zealand's non-European population is disproportionately concentrated in the North Island and especially in the [Auckland Region](#): while Auckland is home to 33% of New Zealand's population, it is home to 62% of the country's Pasifika population and 60% of its Asian population.^[4]

While the [demonym](#) for a New Zealand citizen is New Zealander, the informal "[Kiwi](#)" is commonly used both internationally^[327] and by locals.^[328] The Māori loanword [Pākehā](#) has been used to refer to [New Zealanders of European descent](#), although some reject this name. The word today is increasingly used to refer to all non-Polynesian New Zealanders.^[329]

The Māori were the first people to reach New Zealand, followed by the early [European settlers](#). Following colonisation, immigrants were predominantly from Britain, Ireland and Australia because of restrictive policies similar to the [White Australia policy](#).^[330] There was also significant [Dutch](#), [Dalmatian](#),^[331] German, and Italian immigration, together with indirect European immigration through Australia, North America, South America and South Africa.^{[332][333]} Net migration increased after the [Second World War](#); in the 1970s and 1980s policies on immigration were relaxed, and immigration from Asia was promoted.^{[333][334]} In 2009–10, an annual target of 45,000–50,000 permanent residence approvals was set by the New Zealand Immigration Service—more than one new migrant for every 100 New Zealand residents.^[335] In the 2018 census, 27.4% of people counted were not born in New Zealand, up from 25.2% in the [2013 census](#). Over half (52.4%) of New Zealand's overseas-born population lives in the Auckland Region.^[336] The United Kingdom remains the largest source of New Zealand's immigrant population, with around a quarter of all overseas-born New Zealanders born there; other major sources of New Zealand's overseas-born population are China, India, Australia, South Africa, [Fiji](#) and [Samoa](#).^[337] The number of fee-paying [international students](#) and [international exchange students](#) increased sharply in the late 1990s, with more than 20,000 studying in public [tertiary institutions](#) in 2002.^[338]

Language

Main article: [Languages of New Zealand](#)



Speakers of Māori according to the 2013 census^[339]

Less than 5%

More than 5%

More than 10%

More than 20%

More than 30%

More than 40%

More than 50%

English is the predominant language in New Zealand, spoken by 95.4% of the population.^[340] [New Zealand English](#) is a variety of the language with a distinctive [accent](#) and [lexicon](#).^[341] It is similar to [Australian English](#), and many speakers from the Northern Hemisphere are unable to tell the accents apart.^[342] The most prominent differences between the New Zealand English dialect and other English dialects are the shifts in the short front vowels: the short-*i* sound (as in *kit*) has centralised towards the [schwa](#) sound (the *a* in *comma* and *about*); the short-*e* sound (as in *dress*) has moved towards the short-*i* sound; and the short-*a* sound (as in *trap*) has moved to the short-*e* sound.^[343]

After the Second World War, Māori were discouraged or forced from speaking their own language ([te reo Māori](#)) in schools and workplaces, and it existed as a community language only in a few remote areas.^[344] The Native Schools Act 1867 required instruction in English in all schools, and while there was no official policy banning children from speaking Māori, many suffered from [physical abuse](#) if they did so.^{[345][346][347]} The Māori language has recently undergone a process of revitalisation,^[348] being declared one of New Zealand's official languages in 1987,^[349] and is spoken by 4.0% of the population.^{[340][n 10]} There are now Māori language-immersion schools and two television channels that broadcast predominantly in Māori.^[351] [Many places](#) have both their Māori and English names officially recognised.^[352]

As recorded in the 2018 census,^[340] [Samoan](#) is the most widely spoken non-official language (2.2%), followed by "Northern Chinese" (including [Mandarin](#), 2.0%), [Hindi](#) (1.5%), and French (1.2%). [New Zealand Sign Language](#) was reported to be understood by 22,986 people (0.5%); it became one of New Zealand's official languages in 2006.^[353]

Religion

Main article: [Religion in New Zealand](#)

See also: [Irreligion in New Zealand](#)



A [Rātana](#) church on a hill near [Raetihi](#). The two-tower construction is characteristic of Rātana buildings.^[354]

At the 2023 census, 51.6% of population stated they had [no religion](#),^[355] up from 48.2% in 2018 census.^[340] [Christians](#) are the single largest religious group, forming 32.3% of the population,^[355] compared to 36.5% in 2018.^[340] [Hindus](#) are the second largest religious minority, forming the 2.9% of population, followed by [Muslims](#) on 1.5%.^[355] The Auckland Region exhibited the greatest religious diversity.^[356]

Education

Main articles: [Education in New Zealand](#) and [Tertiary education in New Zealand](#)

Primary and secondary schooling is compulsory for children aged 6 to 16, with the majority of children attending from the age of 5.^[357] There are 13 school years and attending [state \(public\) schools](#) is free to New Zealand citizens and permanent residents from a person's 5th birthday to the end of the calendar year following their 19th birthday.^[358] New Zealand has an adult literacy rate of 99%,^[97] and over half of the population aged 15 to 29 hold a tertiary qualification.^[357] There are five types of government-owned tertiary institutions: universities, colleges of education, [polytechnics](#), specialist colleges, and [wānanga](#),^[359] in addition to private training establishments.^[360] In 2021, in the population aged 25–64; 13% had no formal qualification, 21% had a school qualification, 28% had a tertiary certificate or diploma, and 35% have a bachelor's degree or higher.^[361] The [OECD's Programme for International Student Assessment](#) ranks New Zealand as the 28th best in the OECD for maths, 13th best for science, and 11th best for reading.^[362]

Culture

Main article: [Culture of New Zealand](#)



Late 20th-century house-post depicting the navigator [Kupe](#) fighting two sea creatures

Early Māori adapted the tropically based east [Polynesian culture](#) in line with the challenges associated with a larger and more diverse environment, eventually developing their own distinctive culture. Social organisation was largely communal with families (*whānau*), subtribes (*hapū*) and tribes (*iwi*) ruled by a chief (*rangatira*), whose position was subject to the community's approval.^[363] The British and Irish immigrants brought aspects of their own culture to New Zealand and also influenced Māori culture,^{[364][365]} particularly with the introduction of Christianity.^[366] However, Māori still regard their allegiance to tribal groups as a vital part of [their identity](#), and Māori kinship roles resemble [those of other Polynesian peoples](#).^[367] More recently, [American](#), [Australian](#), [Asian](#) and other [European cultures](#) have exerted influence on New Zealand. Non-Māori Polynesian cultures are also apparent, with [Pasifika](#), the world's largest Polynesian festival, now an annual event in Auckland.^[368]

The largely rural life in early New Zealand led to the image of New Zealanders being rugged, industrious problem solvers.^[369] Modesty was expected and enforced through the "[tall poppy syndrome](#)", where high achievers received harsh criticism.^[370] At the time, New Zealand was not

known as an intellectual country.^[371] From the early 20th century until the late 1960s, Māori culture was suppressed by the attempted [assimilation](#) of Māori into British New Zealanders.^[344] In the 1960s, as tertiary education became more available, and [cities expanded](#)^[372] urban culture began to dominate.^[373] However, rural imagery and themes are common in New Zealand's art, literature and media.^[374]

[New Zealand's national symbols](#) are influenced by natural, historical, and Māori sources. The [silver fern](#) is an emblem appearing on army insignia and sporting team uniforms.^[375] Certain items of popular culture thought to be unique to New Zealand are called "[Kiwiana](#)".^[375]

Art

Main article: [New Zealand art](#)



Portrait of Hinepare of [Ngāti Kahungunu](#) by [Gottfried Lindauer](#), showing chin [moko](#), [pounamu hei-tiki](#) and woven cloak

As part of the resurgence of Māori culture, the traditional crafts of carving and weaving are now more widely practised, and Māori artists are increasing in number and influence.^[376] Most Māori carvings feature human figures, generally with three fingers and either a natural-looking, detailed head or a stylised version.^[377] Surface patterns consisting of spirals, ridges, notches and fish scales decorate most carvings.^[378] The pre-eminent Māori architecture consisted of carved meeting houses ([wharenui](#)) decorated with symbolic carvings and illustrations. These buildings were originally designed to be constantly rebuilt, changing and adapting to different whims or needs.^[379]

Māori decorated the white wood of buildings, canoes and cenotaphs using red (a mixture of red [ochre](#) and shark fat) and black (made from soot) paint and painted pictures of birds, reptiles and other designs on cave walls.^[380] Māori tattoos ([moko](#)) consisting of coloured soot mixed with gum were cut into the flesh with a bone chisel.^[381] Since European arrival paintings and photographs have been dominated by landscapes, originally not as works of art but as factual portrayals of New Zealand.^[382] Portraits of Māori were also common, with early painters often portraying them as an ideal race untainted by civilisation.^[382] The country's isolation delayed the influence of European artistic trends allowing local artists to develop their own distinctive style of [regionalism](#).^[383] During the 1960s and 1970s, many artists combined traditional Māori and Western techniques, creating unique art forms.^[384] New Zealand art and craft has gradually achieved an international audience, with exhibitions in the [Venice Biennale](#) in 2001 and the "Paradise Now" exhibition in New York in 2004.^{[376][385]}

Māori cloaks are made of fine flax fibre and patterned with black, red and white triangles, diamonds and other geometric shapes.^[386] [Greenstone](#) was fashioned into earrings and necklaces, with the most well-known design being the [hei-tiki](#), a distorted human figure sitting cross-legged with its head tilted to the side.^[387] Europeans brought English fashion etiquette to New Zealand, and until the 1950s most people dressed up for social occasions.^[388] Standards have since relaxed and New Zealand fashion has received a reputation for being casual, practical and lacklustre.^{[389][390]} However, the local fashion industry has grown significantly since 2000, doubling exports and increasing from a handful to about 50 established labels, with some labels gaining international recognition.^[390]

Literature

Main article: [New Zealand literature](#)

Māori quickly adopted writing as a means of sharing ideas, and many of their oral stories and poems were converted to the written form.^[391] Most early English literature was obtained from Britain, and it was not until the 1950s when local publishing outlets increased that New Zealand literature started to become widely known.^[392] Although still largely influenced by global trends ([modernism](#)) and events (the Great Depression), writers in the 1930s began to develop stories increasingly focused on their experiences in New Zealand. During this period, literature changed from a [journalistic](#) activity to a more academic pursuit.^[393] Participation in the world wars gave some New Zealand writers a new perspective on New Zealand culture and with the post-war expansion of universities local literature flourished.^[394] Dunedin is a UNESCO [City of Literature](#).^[395]

Media and entertainment

Main articles: [Music of New Zealand](#), [Cinema of New Zealand](#), and [Media of New Zealand](#)



[Lorde](#) is one of the most internationally successful New Zealand artists.

New Zealand music has been influenced by [blues](#), [jazz](#), [country](#), [rock and roll](#) and [hip hop](#), with many of these genres given a unique New Zealand interpretation.^[396] Māori developed a varied [musical tradition](#) around songs and chants, including ceremonial performances, laments, and love songs.^[397] Instruments ([taonga pūoro](#)), such as flutes and percussion, began being used as spiritual tools, entertainment, and signalling devices.^{[398][399]} Early settlers brought over their ethnic music, with [brass bands](#) and [choral music](#) being popular, and musicians began

touring New Zealand in the 1860s.^{[400][401]} [Pipe bands](#) became widespread during the early 20th century.^[402] The New Zealand recording industry began to develop from 1940 onwards, and many New Zealand musicians have obtained success in Britain and the United States.^[396] Some artists release Māori language songs, and the Māori tradition-based art of [kapa haka](#) (song and dance) has made a resurgence.^[403] The [New Zealand Music Awards](#) are held annually by [Recorded Music NZ](#); the awards were first held in 1965 by [Reckitt & Colman](#) as the [Loxene Golden Disc](#) awards.^[404] Recorded Music NZ also publishes the country's [official weekly record charts](#).^[405]



The [Hobbiton Movie Set](#), located near [Matamata](#), was used for [The Lord of the Rings](#) film trilogy.^[406]

Public [radio](#) was introduced in New Zealand in 1922.^[407] A state-owned [television service](#) began in 1960.^[408] Deregulation in the 1980s saw a sudden increase in the numbers of radio and television stations.^[409] New Zealand television primarily broadcasts American and British programming, along with many Australian and local shows.^[410] The number of [New Zealand films](#) significantly increased during the 1970s. In 1978 the [New Zealand Film Commission](#) started assisting local film-makers, and many films attained a world audience, some receiving international acknowledgement.^[409] The highest-grossing New Zealand films are [Hunt for the Wilderpeople](#), [Boy](#), [The World's Fastest Indian](#), [Whale Rider](#), [Once Were Warriors](#), [Heavenly Creatures](#), [What We Do in the Shadows](#) and [The Piano](#).^{[411][412]} The country's diverse scenery and compact size, plus government incentives,^[413] have encouraged some producers to shoot very big-budget and well known productions in New Zealand, including [The Lord of the Rings](#) and [The Hobbit](#) film trilogies, [Avatar](#), [The Chronicles of Narnia](#), [King Kong](#), [Wolverine](#), [The Last Samurai](#), [The Power of the Dog](#), [Alien Covenant](#), [Mulan](#), and [A Minecraft Movie](#).^{[414][415][416]} The New Zealand media industry is dominated by a small number of companies, most of which are foreign-owned, although the [state retains ownership](#) of some television and radio stations.^[417] Since 1994, [Freedom House](#) has consistently ranked New Zealand's press freedom in the top twenty, with the 19th freest media as of 2015.^[418]

Cuisine

Main article: [New Zealand cuisine](#)



Ingredients to be prepared for a [hāngī](#)

The national cuisine has been described as [Pacific Rim](#), incorporating the native [Māori cuisine](#) and diverse culinary traditions introduced by settlers and immigrants from Europe, Polynesia, and Asia.^[419] New Zealand yields produce from land and sea—most crops and livestock, such as maize, potatoes and pigs, were gradually introduced by the early European settlers.^[420] Distinctive ingredients or dishes include [lamb](#), salmon, [kōura](#) (crayfish),^[421] [Bluff oysters](#), [whitebait](#), [pāua](#) (abalone), mussels, scallops, [pipi](#) and [tuatua](#) (types of New Zealand shellfish),^[422] [kūmara](#) (sweet potato), [kiwifruit](#), [tamarillo](#), and [pavlova](#) (considered a national dessert).^{[423][419]} A [hāngī](#) is a traditional Māori method of cooking food using heated rocks buried in a pit oven; still used for large groups on special occasions,^[424] such as [tangihanga](#).^[425]

Sport

Main article: [Sport in New Zealand](#)



A [haka](#) performed by the [national rugby union team](#) ("[All Blacks](#)") before a game. The haka is a challenge with vigorous movements and stamping of the feet.

Most of the major sporting codes played in New Zealand have British origins.^[426] [Rugby union](#) is considered the [national sport](#)^[427] and attracts the most spectators.^[428] [Golf](#), [netball](#), [tennis](#) and [cricket](#) have the highest rates of adult participation, while netball, rugby union and [football \(soccer\)](#) are particularly popular among young people.^{[428][429]} [Horse racing](#) is one of the most popular [spectator sports](#) in New Zealand and was part of the "rugby, racing, and beer" subculture during the 1960s.^[430] Around 54% of New Zealand adolescents participate in sports for their school.^[429] Victorious rugby tours to Australia and the United Kingdom in the [late 1880s](#) and the [early 1900s](#) played an early role in instilling a national identity.^[431] Māori participation in European sports was particularly evident in rugby, and the country's team performs a [haka](#), a traditional Māori challenge, before international matches.^[432] New Zealand is known for its [extreme sports](#), [adventure tourism](#)^[433] and strong [mountaineering](#) tradition, as seen in the success of notable New Zealander [Sir Edmund Hillary](#).^{[434][435]} Other outdoor pursuits such as [cycling](#), fishing, swimming, running, [tramping](#), [canoeing](#), hunting, snowsports, surfing and sailing are also popular.^[436] New Zealand has seen regular sailing success in the [America's Cup](#) regatta since 1995.^[437] The Polynesian sport of [waka ama](#) racing has experienced a resurgence of interest in New Zealand since the 1980s.^[438]

New Zealand has competitive international teams in [rugby union](#), [rugby league](#), [netball](#), [cricket](#), [softball](#), and [sailing](#). New Zealand participated at the [Summer Olympics](#) in 1908 and 1912 as [a joint team with Australia](#), before first participating [on its own](#) in 1920.^[439] The country has ranked highly on a medals-to-population ratio at recent Games.^{[440][441][442]} The [All Blacks](#), the national rugby union team, are the most successful in the history of international rugby.^[443] They have won the [Rugby World Cup](#) three times.^[444]

New Zealand is ranked 5th in the ICC Men's Test Team Rankings 2025 with a rating of 100.^{[\[445\]](#)}